Using the AI editor in PhotoCraft

Edit › Generate Image and Edit › Generative Fill

These two commands ask an OpenRouter image model to make or change a picture. The model runs on OpenRouter's servers, not on your computer. The picture comes back as a new layer. If no document is open, Generate Image opens a new document instead.

The screenshots below are from one session in PhotoCraft. Each OK used OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY and the default model, google/gemini-3.1-flash-lite-image. Both calls returned a picture.

1. Use a standard API key

Create a key at https://openrouter.ai/settings/keys. It has to be a standard inference key. A management or provisioning key can list models and still be rejected when you press OK.

Save it in a file named .env in the folder you start PhotoCraft from. If that file also has an older key, name the inference key OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY. PhotoCraft uses that name first, and OPENROUTER_API_KEY only when OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY is absent:

```
OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY=your-standard-key
```

You can also set that name in the environment. PhotoCraft reads .env only from the folder it was started from, and it never writes the key into the document, a log line, or an error. The browser build has no image API: use the desktop app or photocraft-cli.

2. Where the commands are

Open the Edit menu. Generative Fill... and Generate Image... sit directly under Content-Aware Fill....

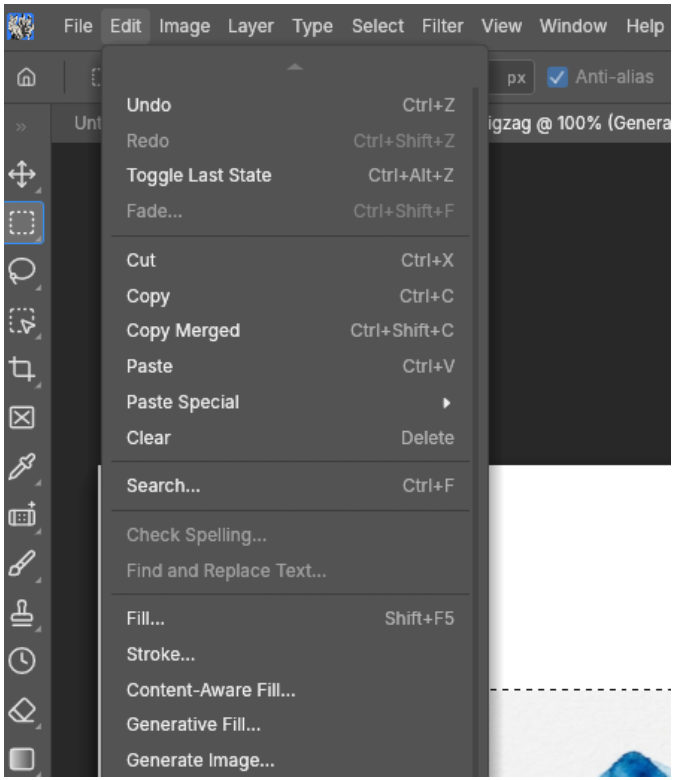


Figure 1. Edit menu. Generative Fill... and Generate Image... follow Content-Aware Fill....

3. Example: generate a new picture

Edit › Generate Image... opens a dialog. Type a prompt, pick an aspect ratio, and press OK. Leave Model empty to use google/gemini-3.1-flash-lite-image.

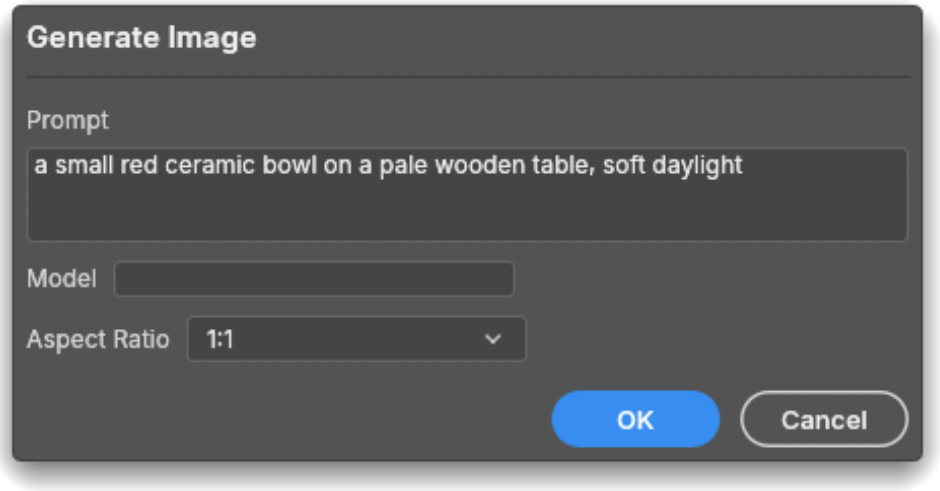


Figure 2. Generate Image with the prompt "a small red ceramic bowl on a pale wooden table, soft daylight" and aspect ratio 1:1.

Pressing OK on that dialog returned a 1024 × 1024 picture. The document was 900 × 640, so PhotoCraft fitted the square inside the canvas and left the side margins white. The new layer is named Generated. The history step and the status bar both say Generate Image.



Figure 3. The picture from Figure 2, on a layer named Generated. The square keeps its shape inside the wider canvas.

What you get:

- A document is open: the picture is fitted inside the canvas, keeping its aspect ratio, on a new layer named Generated. The history step is Generate Image.
- Nothing is open: PhotoCraft opens a new document at the image's own size. The document name is the start of the prompt, and the layer is

named Generated.

More prompts to try:

- a wide dune landscape at sunset, no people — aspect ratio 16:9
- a square flat icon of a blue mountain on a white field — 1:1
- a portrait of a ceramic cup on a gray studio background — 3:4
- an overhead photograph of sliced citrus on dark slate — 4:3

4. Example: change part of a picture

Generative Fill needs a document. Select the area you want to change, then choose Edit › Generative Fill… and describe the change. In this example a black zigzag is drawn on a white canvas, and the rectangular marquee covers the middle of it.



Figure 4. The dashed line is the selection. The prompt is "replace the black zigzag with a soft blue watercolor stroke".

Pressing OK sent the selection, plus a margin of the picture around it, to the same model. The reply is a new layer named Generative Fill. The selection is that layer's mask, so the blue stroke shows only inside the marquee. The black ends, which were outside the selection, are unchanged. In the Layers panel the mask is the black-and-white thumbnail beside the layer.

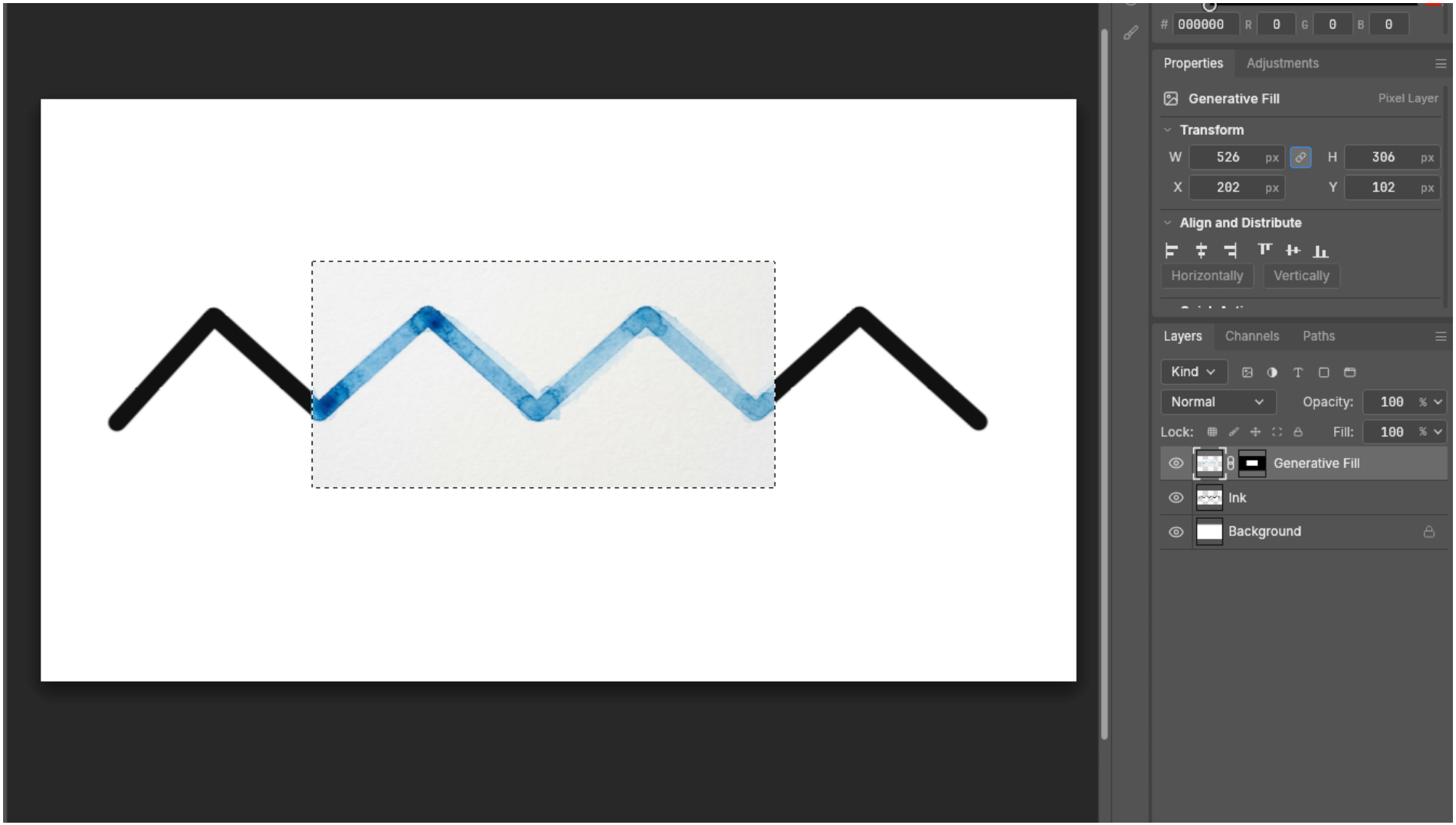


Figure 5. After OK. Blue watercolor replaces the zigzag inside the selection. The black ends stay on the Ink layer underneath.

More prompts to try:

- Select the sky: a bright afternoon sky with a few small clouds.
- Select an empty corner: a small potted plant, matching the light of the room.
- With no selection, the whole canvas is sent. Prompt: turn the whole picture into a pencil sketch.

5. Models and aspect ratio

The Model field takes an OpenRouter image model id. Leave it blank for the default, google/gemini-3.1-flash-lite-image, which accepts a prompt and a reference picture. Other ids you can type:

- google/gemini-3.1-flash-image
- google/gemini-3-pro-image
- openai/gpt-image-1

Generate Image also has Aspect Ratio: 1:1, 16:9, 9:16, 4:3, 3:2, or 3:4. Generative Fill follows the picture you sent, so that dialog has no aspect-ratio field. The picture sent to the model is scaled so its long edge is at most 1024 pixels; the result is scaled back onto the canvas. Each OK spends OpenRouter credits. The two examples above cost about $0.03 each.

6. The same commands from the terminal

photocraft-cli uses the same engine. Start it from the folder that contains .env, or export OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY first. A run always has a document, so Generate Image adds a layer rather than opening a second file.

```
photocraft-cli run --new '{"width":1024,"height":1024}' \
  --cmd edit.generateImage \
  --params '{"prompt":"a small red ceramic bowl on a pale wooden table, soft daylight","aspectRatio":"1:1"}' \
  --out bowl.png
```

```
photocraft-cli run photo.png \
  --cmd edit.generativeFill \
  --params '{"prompt":"replace the black zigzag with a soft blue watercolor stroke"}' \
  --out filled.png
```

To pick another model, add "model" next to "prompt", for example "model":"google/gemini-3-pro-image".

7. If OK does not return a picture

The window stays usable while the request runs. Esc cancels it. A failure is an error notice and the same text in the status bar. An empty prompt is refused before any request is sent.

The examples in this guide did not show an error. They used OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY. The notice below is what you get when the only key is a management or provisioning key, including an older key left in OPENROUTER_API_KEY. PhotoCraft does not use that name when OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY is set.

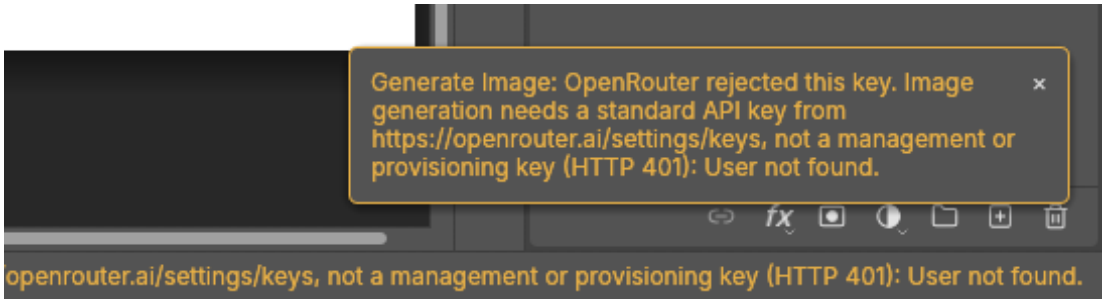


Figure 6. A management or provisioning key is rejected. Put a standard key in OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY.

Other messages you may see:

- PhotoCraft was not started from the folder whose .env defines OPENROUTER_MAIN_KEY or OPENROUTER_API_KEY, and neither variable is set in the environment.
- HTTP 402: the OpenRouter account has no credits.
- HTTP 429: OpenRouter is rate limiting requests. Wait and try again.
- The prompt was empty, or the model id contained spaces or other characters a model id cannot have.